

RADICAL CANDOR

Be a Kick-Ass Boss
Without Losing Your Humanity

KIM SCOTT

The Big “So What”



Great bosses can retain talent and deliver superior results, while bad bosses do the opposite. Most bosses are worried they aren't doing a good job, yet they're afraid to seek help. This book explains how you can become a kickass boss to build sound relationships, achieve results, and create a better workplace.

Introduction



“Bosses” in this book refer generically to all supervisors, leaders and managers. After years of working with top companies in Silicon Valley (such as Google and Apple) and running her own businesses, Scott realized that what sets great bosses apart from bad ones is their ability to build good relationships that keep people happy and challenged. Scott calls this “Radical Candor”. In this summary, we'll outline the philosophies and techniques to apply this framework.

A New Management Philosophy



Bosses achieve results not by doing everything themselves, but by guiding a team to do so. Thus, they must excel in their own work and 3 key areas:



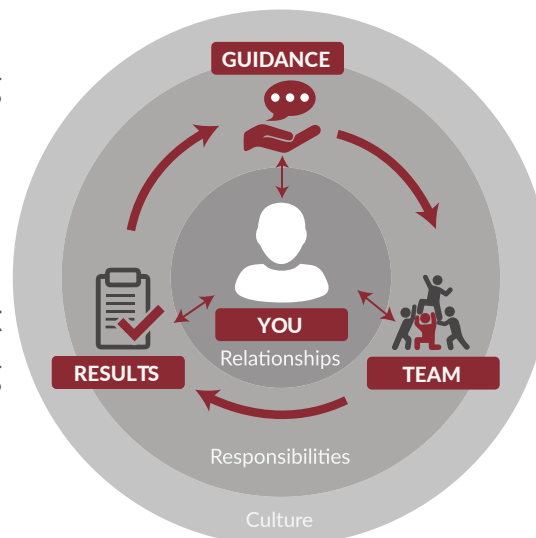
Guidance: soliciting and offering constructive feedback, and encouraging feedback between people;



Team-building: putting the right people in the right roles and keeping them motivated; and



Results: managing your team members to deliver results.



KEY QUOTES

“I hope that these ideas will help you find your own way to be a better boss, have more success at work, and make the world a little happier.”

“Too many good people become bad bosses, and bad bosses are a major source of unhappiness in our world and dysfunction in our workplace.”

“At the very heart of being a good boss...is a good relationship.”

“Guidance, team, and results: these are the responsibilities of any boss.”

“Your ability to build trusting, human connections with the people who report directly to you will determine the quality of everything that follows.”

Building Trusting Relationships



As a boss, your relationships with your direct reports have a huge impact on them and the people they lead. Mutual trust with your direct reports creates a virtuous cycle of constructive feedback, strong teams and results. Radical Candor builds trusting relationships by working concurrently on 2 dimensions:

 **Care personally.** Bring your whole self to work, and care about each of your team members as whole persons with lives and aspirations beyond their work. To do this, you must debunk 2 myths:

- Myth #1: To be professional, you must hide your feelings. Radical Candor is about allowing your direct reports to know you as a person (with hopes and vulnerabilities) and making it safe for others to do the same.
- Myth #2: Bosses are superior. A “boss” is merely a role; it does not define your value or how smart you are.

 **Challenge directly.** Learn to give/receive feedback, make tough decisions and uphold high standards. People may get upset at times, but trust and understanding are eventually built and people feel safe to challenge one another.

Giving/Receiving Guidance



These 4 quadrants summarize how we tend to give guidance/feedback. Note that **they represent behaviors, not personalities**, i.e. no one is an asshole or a saint *all* the time

 **Manipulative insincerity:** you don't care enough to challenge someone directly, and only give feedback in a way that advances your interest, e.g. telling someone he's doing great so he won't quit while quietly planning to replace him. Such behaviors build distrust.



KEY QUOTES

“The relationships you have with the handful of people who report directly to you will have an enormous impact on the results your team achieves.”

“Caring personally is the antidote to both robotic professionalism and managerial arrogance.”

“Being a boss is a job, not a value judgment.”

“If nobody is ever mad at you, you probably aren't challenging your team enough.”

“You need to do that in a way that does not call into question your confidence in their abilities but leaves not too much room for interpretation...and that's a hard thing to do.”
- Steve Jobs

 **Ruinous empathy:** you withhold feedback to avoid conflict or to avoid making others feel bad. You're actually doing your team a disservice because people can't learn/grow if they don't know where they stand, and will eventually stagnate or even get fired. When you accept sub-par work, you also send a wrong message on what's acceptable and make other members bear the burden of the under-performer. This creates resentment and lower standards.

 **Obnoxious aggression:** you criticize someone without first trying to understand them or showing that you care. In such cases, your feedback will seem arrogant and aggressive, and the other party is likely to get defensive or switch off. Patronizing or insincere praise can be as harmful as harsh criticism. The worst thing you can do is to deliberately target someone's vulnerability—this destroys trust and spreads toxic feelings.

 **Radical Candor:** you give someone clear, honest feedback (be it a praise/criticism) for their benefit, and help them to understand how the feedback can help them to move toward their goals. This builds trust and understanding to pave the way for results.

Team: Understand People to Motivate Them



 We tend to define ambition and potential in terms of people's desire and ability to move up the hierarchy. Instead, it may be better to rethink ambition and potential in terms of growth. In any organization, you'll find superstars and rock stars.

- Superstars desire a steep growth trajectory—they crave challenges and opportunities to grow and learn rapidly (though not necessarily get promoted).
- On the other hand, rock stars are solid and prefer a gradual growth trajectory—they may be people who've mastered their craft, love their work and won't be happy if they're promoted to other roles.
- You need both superstars and rock stars for a blend of growth and stability.

KEY QUOTES

"Almost nothing will erode trust more quickly than using one's insights into what makes another person tick to hurt them."

"To build a great team, you need to understand how each person's job fits into their life goals."

"Shifting from a traditional 'talent management' mind-set to one of 'growth management' will help you make sure everyone on your team is moving in the direction of their dreams, ensuring that your team collectively improves over time."



Growth management helps you to motivate individuals to deliver the best possible results based on what they want.

- It involves considering (a) the growth trajectory that each person wants to be on now, and (b) if/how you can match opportunities with their desires bearing in mind the team's overall needs. In short, you must know your direct reports well enough to identify the perfect role for each person at a specific time in his/her life.
- Don't put permanent labels on people. People shift between steep and gradual growth trajectories at various stage of their lives/career. Likewise, no one is always lousy or outstanding; they just happen to be performing poorly or well this quarter.



Managing Top Performers. Treat your rock-stars and superstars as partners. Focus on removing obstacles and giving them everything they need to perform and grow.

- Managing Rock-Stars. At certain phases in their lives, people may slow down due to family/health or to regroup/recharge. They can still grow rapidly as a whole person even if they're growing slowly in their career.
 - (i) Develop *respect for people* on the gradual growth trajectory and recognize the stability they bring. Give *fair ratings* based on performance and contributions in terms of expertise, knowledge etc., not just leadership potential.
 - (ii) Use *other forms of reward and recognition* besides promotion, e.g. a pay raise, bonuses, or giving them roles as go-to experts. They'll probably be much more effective as trainers/mentors than external parties.
- Managing Superstars. Superstars want opportunities to learn, grow and shine. Don't keep them in their current role just to make your work easier, or to hold them back so they won't "overtake" you. Instead, help them to achieve *their* dreams. Find people who can replace them and/or get them to teach others to do their job, so they can move on with minimal gaps.



Manage Middle/Poor Performers. Everyone is good at *something* and no one is a chronic B-Player. Yet, people often stay in a role that they're mediocre at because they don't want to

KEY QUOTES

"Only when you get to know your direct reports well enough to know why they care about their work, what they hope to get out of their careers, and where they are in the present moment in time can you put the right people in the right roles and assign the right projects to the right people."

"Recreation is essential for creation."

"Too many companies hire people for training whom they would never hire to do the actual job."

"Great management is important. But it's certainly not the only path to major impact."

"Raise the bar—there's no such thing as a B-Player."

start afresh, while bosses keep such people because they can't find a replacement or feel bad to remove the person.

- If someone is underperforming, you must first find out why so you can help them improve. There are 5 common reasons why great people may be produce lousy work:
 - (i) They're in a wrong role for their strengths.
 - (ii) They're new to a job and lack training/clear expectations.
 - (iii) They're facing some personal problems.
 - (iv) They have the right skills/experience but the wrong culture fit.
 - (v) They've changed and their roles no longer suit them.
- If someone's really not suited for a job, it's better to let them go so they can find better options elsewhere. Before firing someone, consider (a) if you have given Radically Candid guidance, (b) if/ how the person's poor performance is affecting the rest of the team, and (c) if you've sought an objective opinion.

Driving Results Collaboratively



Use the **Get Stuff Done (GSD) wheel** to adopt a collaborative approach, involve your team in decisions and get buy-in for better long-term results. Don't skip any of these steps.



Listen to ideas that people have, and create a culture of listening. Create systems for staff to share ideas and complaints, define a budget for such issues and explain why certain issues aren't addressed. At meetings, ensure everyone gets to voice their views and listen to others.



Clarify: It's ineffective to try to solve a problem that has not been clearly defined.

KEY QUOTES

"Part of getting a good job is leaving a bad one, or one that's bad for you."

"Don't put people in boxes and leave them there."

"You'll get more done if you take the time to incorporate their thinking into yours, and yours into theirs."

"The essence of making an idea clear requires a deep understanding not only of the idea but also of the person to whom one is explaining the idea."

- Create a safe space to nurture new ideas, e.g. have 1:1 meetings to discuss ideas or give people time off to develop ideas. Don't insist that people only come to you with solutions. Instead, help them to clarify their thinking before they put ideas up for debate.
- Push yourself and your team to clearly express your thoughts and ideas. To present an idea in a clearly comprehensible way, the communicator must understand both the idea and the recipient.

 **Debate** the ideas, polish and test them rigorously. As the boss, you shouldn't be in every debate, but you must create a culture of debate in your team.

- Focus on ideas, not egos. Step in if you see people protecting their ideas or trying to win an argument, instead of seeking facts to improve an idea.
- If everyone at a meeting agrees to something, make it mandatory for someone to offer a different view to force dissent.

 **Decide**. With the earlier steps, your team is ready to make decisions based on facts, not subjective opinions. As the boss, you should not be making most of the decisions. However, occasionally get involved in the details to show nothing's too small for your concern.

 **Persuade** those who haven't been involved so far, but are needed for implementation. You will need to (a) establish your *credibility* by humbly showing your track record, (b) address the listener's *emotional response* (e.g. fatigue, worry), and (c) show your work to illustrate the *logic* behind the idea (vs just explaining with words).

 **Execute**. As the boss, you need to toggle between leading and executing. Don't waste time with unnecessary meetings or reports. To avoid getting too caught up in collaborative tasks, block off time for execution and get your hands dirty occasionally to get a good grasp of what's going on.

 **Learn** from mistakes and start the GSD cycle again. Don't be afraid to change your mind in face of new facts—explain the reasons for the change clearly and persuasively.

KEY QUOTES

"Debate takes time and requires emotional energy. But lack of debate saps a team of more time and emotional energy in the long run."

"Bragging doesn't work, but neither does false humility."

Tools and Techniques



Build Trusting Relationships with your Direct Reports



Center yourself. You can't lead well if you're struggling with your own issues.

- Seek work-life integration by bringing your best self wherever you go. See work as part of your self-expression and life-fulfillment, and see rest/family/personal time as part of improving work productivity.
- Find your own unique formula to stay centered (e.g. mix of sleep, exercise and/or time with loved ones). Commit time for such activities like how you'd show up for an important meeting.



Create the right environment where your team members also feel free to bring their best selves to work, but don't impose your values/ approach on them. Let them do what they're comfortable with.



Use your daily interactions at work to build relationships, so you can minimize redundant social events after work.



Master your emotions. Instead of trying to hide your emotions at work, *recognize your feelings* and let people know what you care about. Master how you react to *others' emotions*. When your direct reports react emotionally, don't second-guess the reason or tell them how they should feel; acknowledge their emotions (e.g. "I can see that you're upset"), ask questions and listen. If you're affected by them, it's ok to ask for a moment to recover and promise to return to the topic.

Giving/Receiving Guidance Effectively



As the boss, it may be awkward to get feedback. To solicit feedback:

- Accept public criticism so people feel safe to speak up. [Note: this applies only to you; team members should be criticized privately.]

KEY QUOTES

"Be relentlessly insistent on bringing your fullest and best self to work—and taking it back home again."

"Live your values. Don't try to list them like an HR exercise."

"It's fine to push yourself past your comfort zone, but not fine to make others uncomfortable."

"Sometimes, the greatest gift you can give your team is to let them go home."

- Use opening questions like “Is there anything I could do or stop doing to make it easier to work with me?” People are likely to claim that everything’s fine. Persist until you get an honest response, e.g. count to 6 and say, “surely there’s something I could do better at”. When people offer feedback, thank them and promise to work on it. Don’t defend yourself.
- When you show that you’ve heard the criticism and are taking action, people will be more likely to share in future. Even if you disagree, find something in the criticism you can agree with. Then, repeat what you’ve heard (to ensure you got it right), say you’d like to think about it and schedule a time to discuss it again.
- Create systems so that criticism feels natural. You can place a feedback box where anyone can drop questions or feedback and pick a few questions to answer during your all-hands meetings. Google holds “management fix-it weeks” where issues raised by staff are consolidated and addressed by assigned managers.



Give impromptu guidance as you make the observations.

- Be humble. Realize that your opinions don’t represent reality.
 - (i) *Situation-behavior-impact*. State the situation, the behavior you saw and the impact you observed. This makes your feedback more precise and less arrogant.
 - (ii) *Left-hand column*. Divide a piece of paper into 2 columns. Think of a frustrating conversation and write down what you said on the right column, and what you thought in the left column. Notice how your assumptions affect your response.
- Focus on helping people to move forward positively.
 - (i) *Share your intention* to lower defences, e.g. “I’m going to share an observation which I hope will help with your project. If I’m wrong, please feel free to tell me.”
 - (ii) *Be specific*. It’s more useful to say “she explained the problem and solution clearly in 5 minutes” than “she is brilliant.”
 - (iii) You don’t have to *fix things yourself*, e.g. to help a staff who stammers, you can suggest a speech coach or get their views.

KEY QUOTES

- Give feedback immediately while the details are still fresh in your minds. When you withhold the feedback, it may create pent-up frustrations and leave people wondering how they're doing.
- Ideally, do it face-to-face so you can clarify or adjust your message based on their body language. If this is not possible, go for a video call or phone call (in order of effectiveness). Avoid email or text as they tend to create misunderstanding. Follow up on 1:1 feedback with an email to the whole team for best results.
- As a rule of thumb, praise in public and criticize in private. Praising someone publicly makes them feel good and help others to learn what went right. Criticize in private so you can take time to understand them and move them forward positively.
- Don't personalize praises or criticisms (e.g. assume someone is lazy or greedy rather than acting out of situational factors). It's often inaccurate and makes the problem harder to solve. To avoid personalization, (a) use the situation-behavior-impact or the lefthand column techniques and (b) use words like "that's wrong" or "I think that's wrong" (not "you're wrong").



Formal performance reviews are vital for reinforcing the informal feedback. Solicit feedback for yourself first, and use 360 degree feedback if possible so the appraisal doesn't seem like a 1-way judgement.

- Write down what you want to say before the review: it gives you clarity and gives people a chance to return for clarification later.
- Spend 50% on past performance and 50% on the future. Get your direct reports to come up with their development plan and identify what they'd do differently.
- Set aside enough time, with $\geq 50\text{min}$ for each person and $\geq 10\text{min}$ between sessions so you can recover emotionally. Schedule regular follow ups to assess how the plan is working.
- Hold separate sessions for performance review vs rating/compensation. This prevents people from being so distracted by compensation that they can't focus on improvements.

KEY QUOTES

"If you don't know whether what you said was clear to the other person, you may as well not have said it."

"Caring personally is good. Personalizing is bad."

"Don't let perfection be the enemy of good."



Encourage peer guidance, e.g. at all-hands meetings, you can (a) get people to share stories of exceptional work by colleagues and vote for them and (b) let people confess their screw-ups to help others avoid the same mistake. However, don't let any member of your team talk to you about another team member behind their back; if need be, hold 3-way conversations to resolve the conflict.



Never try radical candor on your boss by criticizing him/her. Instead, roll out Radical Candor with your own team and only explain it to your boss if the opportunity arises. You can also ask your boss for guidance (rather than giving it). No matter how receptive your boss seems, don't give guidance without seeking permission, e.g. by asking "would it be helpful if I shared what I thought about this issue?"



Once a year, you can do "skip-level meetings" with the staff reporting to your direct reports (without the direct reports around).

- Explain your goal—to help your direct reports become better bosses and help their staff feel comfortable to give feedback. Then, demonstrate it by asking your boss to do a skip-level on you. Always get your direct report's prior consent, and do it for *all* your direct reports (not selectively).
- Get feedback on what the manager is doing well, what could be better, then what sucks. Take the notes yourself and verify the notes with the team before you finalize them, to make sure you got it right. Share the notes right after the meeting. Share all feedback with the direct report, but not who said it.
- Work with your direct reports to identify 1-2 specific things they can change immediately. Get them to share with their teams what they've learned and what they intend to do differently.

Managing your Team for High Performance



Hold career conversations to understand each of your direct reports' ambitions, so you can help them move toward their dreams.

KEY QUOTES

"Open, fair, and fast conflict resolution is one of the services you owe your direct reports."

"Giving space for people to talk about dreams allows bosses to help people find opportunities that can move them in the direction of those dreams".

- Ask about their lives since childhood and why they made the key changes they did. These can shed light on their key values and what matters most to them.
- Learn about their dreams, i.e. what they envisage their career and best life to be like. Don't ask for their "career aspirations" or "5-year plans" which tend invite formal replies. Get them to follow up with a list of their key dreams, the skills needed (in order of importance) and their current competency level.
- Work with each direct report on an 18-month plan. Jointly identify specific ways to narrow the key skills gaps, e.g. useful people/resources or how to change their roles to help them learn the required skills.



Create a growth management plan for each direct report yearly.

- Put names temporarily into 3 groups: top performers, good performers, and underperformer. Then, validate this with someone who's familiar with your team's work.

Poor Performance (Strong signs of improvement)		Growth (Superstars)
Poor Performance (No signs of improvement)	Good (but not exceptional) performance	Stability (Rockstars)

- Develop growth plans for each person with 3-5 bullet points (e.g. projects to stretch superstars, support for rock stars, ways to help good/poor performers to improve).
- Compare notes with your peers doing similar plans, to avoid biased ratings, build shared standards and perceived fairness.



Invest in hiring the right people with the skills *and* team fit.

- Don't rely on paper qualifications alone for pre-screening. Use projects or problems to assess the potential candidates' skills.
- Don't make the decision on your own. To reduce subjectivity and bias, use an interview committee with ideally 4 people of varying background, e.g. gender, ethnicity, teams.
- Use casual interactions for deeper insights. Talk to candidates over lunch, walk them to their car, or ask the receptionist about their experience with the candidate.

KEY QUOTES

"It's scary to move confidently in the direction of one's dreams. Part of your responsibility as the boss is to help people find the courage to do just that."

- Jot down your thoughts after each interview, and have the committee meet after every 3-4 candidates for a debrief. Don't make an offer if you're not dying to hire the person, or if another interviewer feels strongly against hiring the person.



Firing people. Once you identify someone with performance issues:

- Don't wait too long to admit he/she is underperforming. Delaying is unfair for everyone as (a) the staff has less time to address the issues, (b) the company needs time for proper processes in case you must fire the person, (c) it's bad for your reputation and (d) your team will be affected by this member's performance.
- Don't just follow HR/legal processes. Consider the staff's needs and remember that they're not bad people; they've just been hired for a job that's bad for them.



Promote fairly. You can use calibration meetings between bosses to ensure promotions are fair. At Google, anyone can recommend themselves for promotions and decisions are made by a committee than by the managers.



Reward both rock stars and superstars. Don't over-emphasize promotions and status—praise and celebrate exceptional work, innovation, teamwork, efficiency etc. Say “thank you” in person, publicly and/or via a note, explaining why the work matters and why it matters to you. Find ways to recognize people for their areas of expertise, e.g. put them in charge of teaching others or create opportunities for their work to be shared publicly/made more visible.

Improve Results with Better Communication



Radical Candor is fundamentally about improving team collaboration for results. This requires great communication at each step of the GSD wheel.



1:1 Conversations. These are informal sessions where your direct reports set the agenda to discuss what matters to *them*. Your role is to listen, help them gain clarity, and get to know them personally.

KEY QUOTES

“Remember, the reason you have to fire them is not that they suck. It's not even that they suck at this job. It's that this job—the job you gave them—sucks for them”

“Focus on the work the person is doing, not the status they've achieved in the company for doing it.”

“The ultimate goal of Radical Candor is to achieve results collaboratively that you could never achieve individually.”

- Follow *their agenda, not yours*, though you can set the structure and ground-rules. Use questions like “why?”, “how can I help?”, “what can you do to...?” to help them clarify their thinking. Make this a safe space for people to bounce or nurture new ideas.
- Choose a *frequency* that works for your team size. Ideally, set aside 50 minutes weekly for up to 10 direct reports each. Never cancel your 1:1 meetings.



Staff meetings should meet 3 key goals:

- *Learn (20min)*. Prepare your key metrics, so you can identify what went well or badly the previous week, and why.
- *Share (15min)*. Take 5-7 minutes for everyone to write down 3-5 important updates that others need to know (e.g. potential reorganization, revised targets). Then, take another 5-7 minutes to read others’ updates without discussion.
- *Clarify (30min)*. Define the 1-2 most important decisions and the 1 most important debate for that coming week, for your next Big Debate and Big Decision meetings. Share the topics/ agenda in advance with the rest of the team. Besides those identified to be present, anyone else can attend if they wish to.



Big Debate meetings force you to take time to consider key decisions deeply, and to build a culture of debate. The “owner” of the session must ensure that people put their egos aside to focus on gathering facts, clarifying issues/options and finding the best answers before you move into decision-making.



Big Decision meetings force you to stop debating and start deciding. The “decider” must ensure that the best decision is made based on facts, not egos. Anyone can attend the meeting—once the decision is made, it’s final and notes are shared with everyone involved. If someone with veto power can’t be present, he/she must indicate prior so the decision can be approved before the notes are released.



As the team gets bigger, it’s harder to get buy-in from people. All-hands meetings help you to reach everyone. They typically include a presentation to persuade people about the company’s direction, and Q&As to encourage dissent and address questions.

KEY QUOTES

“When you’re the boss and shit happens, it’s your responsibility to learn from it and make a change.”



Thinking time. Block off 1-2 hours on your calendar daily just to clarify your own thinking (and let your team members do the same).



Execution time. Block off meeting-free slots in your calendar where you can be alone and focus on execution.



Kanban Boards are shared boards with 3 columns: To Do, In Progress and Done. Each person/team writes down their tasks on different colored post-its and move them around the board. That way, everyone can see the overall workflow, progress, bottlenecks, and build respect and understanding of others' work.



Make time to walk around, observe what's going on and ask people about their work and challenges. It allows you to stay in touch with large numbers of staff beyond your direct reports, and shows that no detail is too small for your attention.



Be culture-conscious. As a boss, everything you say and do (or don't) has ripple effects across the organization. Every small detail—from the name of your annual party to how you respond to mistakes—shapes the culture. Once something is embedded in your culture, it takes a life of its own.

Conclusion & Details in the Book to Look out For



Radical Candor takes time and energy to implement, but the results can be massive, as new ideas emerge and problems get solved without your involvement as the boss.

To get started, share your own stories and invite feedback while getting to know your people with career conversations and 1:1 conversations. When you (a) are better at getting/giving guidance (b) know your direct reports and (c) are happy with your 1:1s, you can move on to staff meetings, debate and decision meetings to improve productivity, before working on growth-management plans and rewards, as well as company processes like hiring, firing, promotion, and formal performance reviews. The book includes numerous other examples and detailed tips on the philosophy and techniques of applying Radical Candor. For more details, please visit www.radicalcandor.com.

KEY QUOTES

"Being ruthless about making sure your team has time to execute is one of the most important things you can do as a boss."

"The small choices you make will persuade people to act in accordance with the culture you want to build with your team."

"A team's culture has an enormous impact on its results, and a leader's personality has a huge impact on a team's culture."